The Rapture of the Church

Grief with hope — Christ descends, the dead in Christ rise first, and the church is caught up together. People looking for the undertaker ought to be looking for the upper-taker.

Where this study fits

1 Thessalonians · ten studies · this study highlighted

01 1:1–5
An Introduction to the Thessalonian Church

02 1:6–10
The Many Faces of the Gospel

03 2:1–12
Delivering the Gospel

04 2:13–20
A Successful Life of Service

05 3:1–13
Facing Tribulation

06 4:1–12
A Life That Pleases God

07 4:13–18
The Rapture of the Church

08 5:1–11
The Coming of the Lord: A Purifying Hope

09 5:12–22
The Coming of the Lord: Exhortations

10 5:23–28
'Til We Meet Again

"Finally" (4:1) marks the hinge: chapters 1–3 lay the foundation; chapters 4–5 turn that theology into life.

Israel and the Church

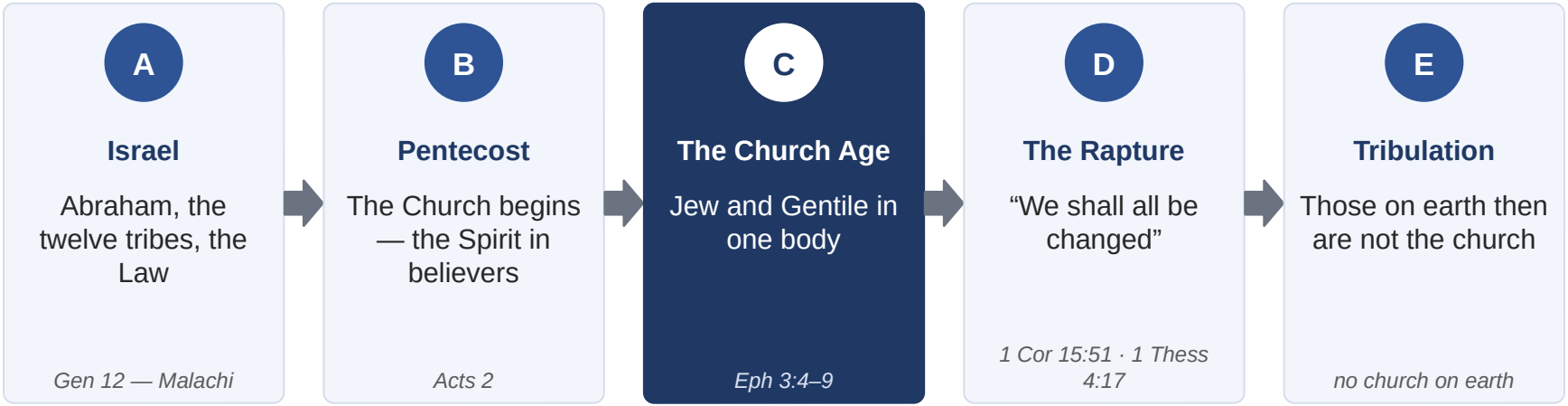
I.A–B · The theological setting

Israel — the Old Testament		The Church — a mystery
• From the call of Abraham (Gen 12) • The Old Covenant — the Law • Physical promises: a land, a kingdom • A literal 1,000-year reign of Christ	≠	• From Pentecost to the Rapture • The New Covenant (Heb 7–10) • Spiritual promises • “Christ in you, the hope of glory” (Col 1:26)

Israel is not — in any way — the Church. The Church is not — in any way — Israel. The Church was hidden in God (Eph 3:9), not in the Old Testament.

The Church on the timeline

I.B · Pentecost to the Rapture



There was no church on earth before Acts 2 at Pentecost. And there will be no church on earth after the Rapture. It is a unique entity in the plan of God.

Where are the believers who have died?

1 Thessalonians 4:13–14 · II.A — A preview

The body sleeps

κοιμάω to sleep · G2837

- In the grave, an urn, the ocean
- Sleep ends with waking
- “The dead in Christ will rise first” (v.16)

+

The soul is with the Lord

ἄγω will bring · G71

- Absent from the body, present with the Lord (2 Cor 5:8)
- “Far better” (Phil 1:23)
- Comes down with Him (v.14)

“Since we believe that Jesus died and rose again” — a first-class condition. If He rose, they rise. We sorrow, but not as others who have no hope (ἐλπίς).

The Rapture, verse by verse

1 Thessalonians 4:13–18 · II.A–C — Preview, promise, picture

v.13	Don’t be uninformed; don’t grieve as those without hope	**κοιμάω · ἐλπίς** asleep, not lost
v.14	Since Jesus died and rose, God will bring them with Him	**ἄγω** will bring — purposeful motion
v.15	By the word of the Lord: the living will not precede the dead	**φθάνω · παρουσία** no believer gets there first
v.16a	The Lord Himself descends — shout, archangel, trumpet	**κέλευσμα** a commanding shout
v.16b	The dead in Christ will rise first	**—** they are going ahead
v.17	Caught up together to meet the Lord in the air	**ἁρπάζω · ἀπάντησις** sudden taking · to meet
v.18	Therefore comfort one another with these words	**παρακαλέω** the doctrine’s purpose

Three sounds at one moment

1 Thessalonians 4:16 · II.C.1 — The resurrection

The shout
κέλευσμα keleusma · G2752

- Only here in the NT
- A shouted order: hunter to hounds
- Lazarus was called by name — this shout has none

The archangel's voice
ἀρχάγγελος archangelos · G743

- Ruler of angels
- Scripture names one: Michael
- Jude 9; Rev 12:7

The trumpet of God
σάλπιγξ salpinx · G4536

- A summons, an assembly, a King's arrival
- All three converge here

"Come forth" — addressed to every believer who has ever died. The dead in Christ will rise first.

Five marks of a comforting truth

1 Thessalonians 4:18 · II.C.3 — The reassurance (John Phillips)

A **Positive truth**

“Shall” — not a possibility; a certainty

B **Personal truth**

We, us, I, you — addressed to individuals

C **Pivotal truth**

“But” (v.13) marks a turn: don’t be ignorant

D **Progressive truth**

“For” links each verse to the next

E **Practical truth**

“Therefore” — applied at once

✓ **παρακαλέω · v.18**

“Comfort one another” — the Spirit’s own ministry

Discuss and apply

1 Thessalonians 4:13–18 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. Verse 14 says God will bring with Him those who sleep in Jesus; verse 16 says the dead in Christ rise first. How can both be true — and what does it teach about body and soul at death?

2. Paul expected to be alive at the Rapture (“we who are alive”). What is the practical effect of living with that expectation — and how does it differ from speculating about dates?

Apply

Hold the Blessed Hope

Begin each morning this week with one sentence: “The Lord may come today.” Notice what it changes.

Comfort One Another

Reach out to one grieving or discouraged person with a verse from this passage and a personal word.

In one line: The dead in Christ are not lost — they rise first, we are caught up together, and we will always be with the Lord.